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A WEEK AFTER THE INAUGURATION, we held a ceremony on the South Lawn of the White House welcoming home the fifty-two hostages who, thank God, had finally been freed from their long captivity in Iran. Also present were relatives of the eight men who had lost their lives during the unsuccessful attempt to rescue the hostages during the previous administration; one courageous couple had lost their only son, and as I looked into their faces I had difficulty finding the words to lessen their terrible sense of grief.

For the rest of the day, I carried around a lump in my throat as big as a mountain. Unfortunately, it would not be the last time I would have to try to console the relatives of men and women who died in the service of our country. That morning, I was introduced to the worst part of my new job.

The Algerian and Swiss go-betweens who represented us during the hostage negotiations with the Iranians said that the final weeks of negotiations had been dominated by a concern among Iranian officials that they would have to do business with the new administration. In the weeks leading up to the inauguration, I had gone out of my way to say some nasty things in public about the Ayatollah Khomeini, hoping it would encourage him to expedite the negotiations before we arrived in Washington. I referred to them at one time as barbarians. Whether this had anything to do with the hostages' release on inauguration day, I don't know, but the job wasn't complete. An American writer had gone to Iran shortly before the hostages were freed and had been arrested upon her arrival in Teheran; she had been charged with being a spy and thrown in jail.